California, US senator Gaylord Nelson proposed the idea of a national event to highlight the varied threats to the environment. On the first Earth Day, which took place on April 22, 1970, millions turned out on marches across the US. The scale of the event helped the passage of the Clean Air, Clean Water, and Endangered Species Acts and led to the creation of the United States Environmental Protection Agency (EPA).

In 1973, German economist Ernst Schumacher used the term “natural capital” in his best-seller *Small is Beautiful* to describe how ecosystems provide us with complex services. The concept inspired American environmentalist Gretchen Daily and others, who argued that ecosystems are capital assets which, when properly managed, provide a flow of vital goods and services.

International cooperation

Two UN agencies—the World Meteorological Organization and the UN Environment Programme—established the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) in 1988 to assess the risk of human-induced climate change.

International cooperation is now seen as key to saving Earth’s environment. Examples of such cooperation include the Rio Earth Summit in 1992, which aimed to achieve global agreement on greenhouse gas emissions, and the adoption in 2022 of the Kunming–Montreal Global Biodiversity Framework, which aims to halt and reverse biodiversity loss.

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